

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

LESSONS IN PODIATRY

Errant officials in Bihar are having to watch their feet. Displeased with the slow pace of work in sundry projects, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar is now going for their feet to shame them into action. So, on July 10, it was a manager of a project in the road construction department who was pulled up for the snail's pace of progress and asked, "*Kahiye to aapke pair chhu lun* (Allow me to touch your feet)," even as the Bihar chief minister mock dived for the hapless official's feet. A week earlier, on July 3, Nitish, frustrated by the slow pace of land survey in the state, had quipped, "*Main haath jodta hun, kahiye to pair bhi chhu lun* (I fold my hands, should I touch your feet too)?" But it is not always sarcasm that has Nitish seeking people's feet. On June 7, it was to pay his respects that Nitish tried to touch PM Narendra Modi's feet after promising support to his government. It's a handy skill, touching feet, for humiliation, and humility.

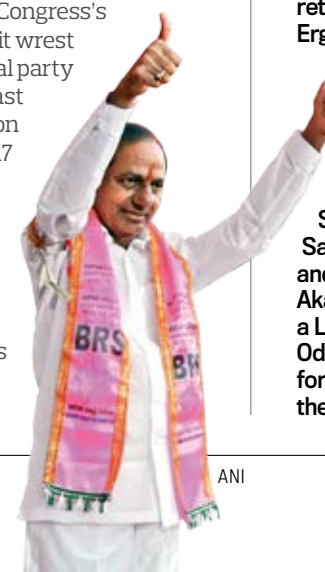
UNJUSTIFIED FEAR



When Parliament passed the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA) in December 2019, Assam had erupted in violent protests, resulting in five deaths. Fear surged that the CAA would flood the state with illegal Hindu immigrants from Bangladesh, changing Assam's demographics. Assam CM **Himanta Biswa Sarma**, a staunch CAA advocate, had dismissed these concerns. Now, the BJP stalwart may have the last laugh. Since the CAA rules were framed in February, only eight individuals in Assam have applied for citizenship under the Act—a number hardly capable of causing a demographic upheaval.

The Hex of Six

Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) supremo **K. Chandrashekar Rao** had laid great store by the number six. Now, it seems to be turning against him. Six MLCs deserted the party on July 4 amid apprehensions of a meltdown, triggered by the string of switches by BRS MLAs to the Grand Old Party. Things haven't been quite the same for KCR ever since the Congress's six guarantees helped it wrest power from the regional party in the assembly polls last November, a humiliation compounded by its 0/17 score in the Lok Sabha election. Already, 10 of the BRS's 38 MLAs have switched sides. Now, the Congress is predicting July 24, which adds up to six, as the date for the BRS's complete downfall.



ANI



War Against Wires

You may not even notice them now, the hanging wires that have become a part of the Chandni Chowk landscape. Monkeys even use them for their daily commute. But loose live wires have also caused innumerable deaths by electrocution over the years, and are "a ticking time bomb, a constant threat to life and property", as the area's new MP **Praveen Khandelwal** pointed out. And so, right after taking oath, Khandelwal set about meeting Delhi government officials, outlining his plans to untangle the unsightly and dangerous mess of electric wires. The solution is to send them underground. But in the narrow bylanes of Purani Dilli, that is a task easier said than done.



NATIVE ASSERTIONS

It was only a matter of time before the new BJP government in Odisha amped up its Odia pride campaign, one that had delivered successful returns in the state election. Ergo, the **Mohan Charan Majhi** government has now mandated Odia be used as language of official communication. Also on the cards are a restructuring of the Odisha Sahitya Akademi, the Odisha Sangeet Natak Akademi and the Odisha Lalit Kala Akademi, and the setting up of a Language Commission. The Odia Bhasa Pratisthan too is up for reconstitution to promote the language in the state.

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Amarnath K. Menon, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Avishek G. Dastidar